

American Intervention in Laos

By 1960, Laos was in the throes of a civil war, with various factions vying for control. Both the US and North Vietnam intervened—North Vietnam to access the Ho Chi Minh Trail, and the US to build a secret army to fight the communist Pathet Lao.

◀◀ BEFORE

Laos gained independence from France in 1953, leading to an internal power struggle. Laos soon learned that freedom from the French did not mean freedom from Western intervention.

BROTHERS AT ODDS

Since gaining its independence, Laos had been torn by internal divisions exacerbated by outside interference. Prince Souvanna Phouma's attempts to **unify the nation** under a coalition government had failed, while the communist **Pathet Lao**, led by Prince Souphanouvong, had gained control over the northeast of the country. To US President Eisenhower, keeping Laos out of communist hands was even more important than supporting the Diem regime in Vietnam, but providing **US financial assistance** had done nothing to stabilize the situation.



GOLD FRIEZE COMMEMORATING LAOTIAN INDEPENDENCE

The US had been pumping resources into Vietnam's neighbor, Laos, in an attempt to establish a pro-Western government, but the country was a political quagmire. Eisenhower's response was to send in small Special Forces detachments as military advisers. The first of them, initially posing as contract civilian specialists, arrived in July 1959, just as the rainy season started.

The teams were drawn from the Seventh Special Forces Group stationed at Fort Bragg in North Carolina. There were 12 of them, plus a control team, which was posted to Vientiane, the Laotian capital. The others were sent to four rear-area training sites. Each team consisted of a team leader and his assistant, two light weapons specialists, a medical expert and an aidman, a radio operator, and a motor maintenance engineer. Each team's tour of duty lasted six months.

Special Forces in action

Initially, the teams were restricted to working simply as instructors, but in August 1960 they found themselves caught up in the civil war between neutralists—who backed a neutral foreign policy—and pro-Westerners, with the communist Pathet Lao waiting in the wings. That November, Special Forces detachments went into action as combat advisers to